



Also Remember...

- When you send a long message you charged for each 160 letters. Hence if you send a message which consists of 450 letters, you will be charged for three messages by your service provider.
- Tri-Band phones give you the convenience of talking in five continents. However, make sure your service provider has tie-up's internationally which will connect you international networks.
- While opting for a roaming scheme your service provider may not provide outgoing calls from all states.

A few years ago, a cellular phone was considered a luxury item. However, with tariffs going down, owning a cell phone has become a necessity. And most people do own one, right from your neighbour's school-going kid to your local *subziwallah*. In fact, things will soon reach a state where not having a cell phone is a sign that you've arrived—a subtle message that hints: "Look, I'm far too important to be at your beck and call all the time!"

Joking apart, a cellular phone today is more than just a phone. It allows you to store applications, manage meetings, appointments, etc. More over, newer phones come with a built-in camera, giving the PDA market a run for its money. Cellular handset manufacturers have been flooding the market with new models, and this can only make your buying decision more complicated.

So which is the right phone for you? If you wish to use the phone simply for messaging and receiving calls, you can get a good deal for Rs 5,000. However, if you're looking at features such as calendar, PC synchronisation, Bluetooth connectivity, voice recorder, WAP browser etc, you could end up paying anywhere from Rs 10,000 to Rs 16,000. Phones bundled with a camera and multimedia messaging could set you back by Rs 20,000 to Rs 40,000.

Market Overview

With the market growing, even Indian brands such as VKMunoth have made an appearance,

and depending on their success, more will follow. The entry-level price of a cell phone has dropped around 15 to 25 per cent over the past year, and basic phones such as the Nokia 3315, Sony Ericsson T100, T200 now cost between Rs 4,800 and Rs 5,800.

In the mid-range segment, which has some additional features such as calendaring, large capacity address book, larger screens, IrDA ports and so on, prices hover between Rs 10,000 and Rs 20,000. This is also the largest category of cellular phones. Phones such as the Nokia 6310, and 8310i are among the more popular models. On the other hand, Sony Ericsson's T68i does not have many buyers despite a relatively low price of around Rs 15,000. This is because there's very little awareness among users, even though the phone has been available for more than a year.

In the high-end segment, Nokia's 3650 with a built-in camera is the latest craze. In the premium segment the latest entrant from Sony Ericsson is the P800. Sold at around Rs 40,000, this comes with plenty of features to justify the price tag.

Prices in India are still on the higher side when compared with international markets, at least in the premium segment. Hence a lot of models get smuggled into the country through grey channels, and are available at lower rates. But with the industry maturing, this price difference has decreased, especially in the entry-level and mid-range segments.

Market Scenario

The 'wired' society is giving way to one that is wireless. Computing is getting legs, with people increasingly accessing the Internet and communicating with each other via small, hand-held electronic devices such as cell phones and personal digital assistants (PDAs). Freed from the plug, these

devices provide access to information anytime, anywhere.

Prices for entry-level cellphones begin from about Rs 4,000 and go up to about Rs 40,000. Most users however will probably find a suitable cellphone for less than Rs 10,000.

Decision Maker			
	Basic use	Amateur enthusiast	Performance Seeker
You need	Average looks with basic features	Sleek looks with PC connectivity	Camera, PDA, Tri-band, external Memory module support
Look for	A phone that gives 100 or more phone book entries	Phone book with a storage capacity of 500 names and 150 SMS, GPRS, infrared or Bluetooth connectivity	Camera supporting a resolution of 640 x 480, loads of internal memory, fast CPU.
Our pick	Nokia 2100	Sony Ericsson T68i, Nokia 6310i	Nokia 3650, Sony Ericsson P-800
Price range	Up to Rs 7,000	Up to Rs 15,000	Up to Rs 40,000